company; at first, the switchboard operator wouldn't believe it was me and refused to let me speak to the manager. But I finally got through. I'm not sure my call had anything to do with it, but the young man got the job.

It was also always a thrill to witness the kindness and generosity of the American people from the vantage point of the Oval Office. You could measure it by the growth of volunteer programs around the country and see it swing into action whenever there was a major flood, a hurricane, or other emergency: Americans would rush in to help other Americans. Countless times, I observed this phenomenon on a smaller scale, too. There was the couple in Connecticut who had adopted twelve children, all as deformed and handicapped babies—the kind of children who unfortunately are frequently victims of infanticide. I called and spoke to the couple and then to all of the children, and I could feel the love and joy in that household radiating over the telephone wires like a burst of sunshine. If there were people who needed proof that God had a purpose for each of us, I thought, let them meet that family.

Once I was asked by a group of children whether I liked being president, and I told them I enjoyed the job very much. There were moments, I said, of great grief. As I've said, the hardest part of the job was having to send young men and women into situations of danger and then having to tell the families of some why they weren't coming back. But, I told them, there were also many moments of great joy, and I enjoyed being president very much.

Part of it, I said, was being able to have my hand on the throttle after so many years of preaching about my views on the problems of government; now I could try to do something about them.

I even enjoyed the give and take of battling Congress—including Tip O'Neill. But it was more than that: Maybe the most fun of all, I told the children, was being able to pick up